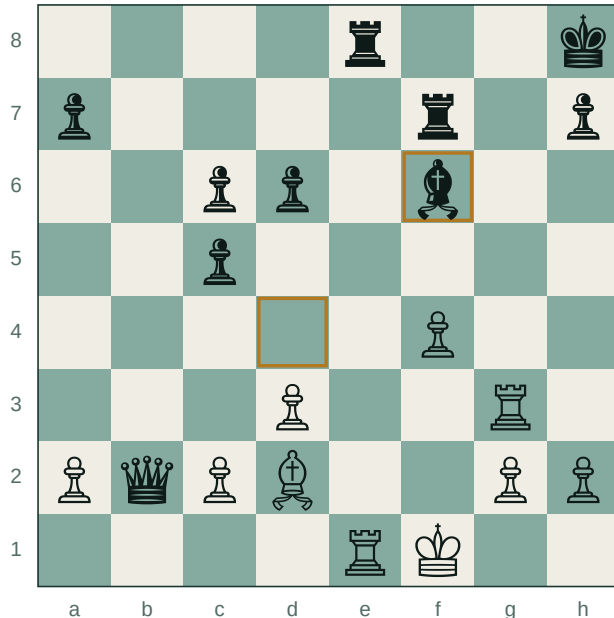


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 22

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 21...Bxf6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

22. Rxe8+ Rf8 23. Rxf8#

22.Rxe8+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the rook on e8. Recorded reply: **22...Rf8**.

23.Rxf8# Mate: rook on f8 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on h8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on f8. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on h8. Geometrically undefended: rook on e8 and rook on f7. Check for tactical protection.